Deciding with AI: A Student Field Guide

Jeremy Evert · November 9, 2026

A digital assistant is fast, clever, and tireless, but a poor boss: use it to gather and organize information (then check it), widen, sharpen and stress-test options, then make the call yourself.

Start here

You do not have to read this front to back. The first time, spend a few minutes on a real decision that matters to you (what to study or how to study, which laptop to buy or if you need to, how to design a project or evaluate a good project design) and follow these steps:

1. Write the decision in one sentence, then fill in Steps 1 and 2 of the Decision Worksheet at the end. Do it before you open an AI.
2. Open an AI and paste **The briefing** from "Prompts to copy." Answer its questions.
3. Paste **Compare** with your own criteria. Read what comes back with a pencil in hand.
4. Open a second AI in a fresh chat and paste **All six at once** from "Catch the AI in a lie," with the first answer underneath. For the best results, ask the six questions one at a time. All six at once is the fast version.
5. Pick the one claim that would hurt most if it were wrong, and check it outside the chat: a real source, a test you run, or a person.
6. Finish the Decision Worksheet. If you can explain your choice out loud, you are done.

No AI available? Every prompt in this guide works as a list of questions for a classmate or a teacher.

What assistants do well, and where they trip

A good assistant is remarkable at some jobs and unreliable at others, and it sounds equally sure in both. Use the left column freely. Check the right column whenever it matters.

Great at	Watch out for
Gathering and summarizing a lot of information, fast	Invented facts, sources and numbers; information that is out of date
Brainstorming options and angles you had not thought of	Options it cannot know about, because it does not know your situation unless you say so
Explaining an idea in plain words, at your level	Smooth, convincing explanations of things that are wrong
Drafting, rewording and reorganizing	Flattery, and a voice that is not yours
Comparing options and spotting risks	Quietly choosing your values for you
Patient, tireless, available at 2 a.m.	It does not know when it does not know

You already know how to do this

An assistant is not a new concept, though using a competent digital assistant is still a little novel. Getting assistance, and getting it well, is not a new skill. It is skills you already have, pointed at a new tool.

In real life	What you already know	With an AI
GPS	It is usually right, until it routes you down a closed road. You are still the driver.	Follow it on easy turns. Look up from the screen when the stakes are high.
Asking a stranger for directions	People answer confidently even when guessing.	Ask a second person: a second AI.
The friend who loves every idea	"Great plan!" feels good and tells you nothing.	Ask for the case against. Run the pressure test.
Instructions for a babysitter or new coworker	"Be nice to the kids" is not enough. They need who, when, rules and who to call.	Goal, context, constraints, format.
A calculator in math class	It is fast, but you still need to know roughly what the answer should be.	Estimate first, then sanity-check what comes back.

In real life	What you already know	With an AI
The group-project teammate	"Yeah, I did my part." Then you open the file.	Run it yourself. "All tests pass" is a claim.
Gossip and the telephone game	Five people repeating a rumor is still one rumor.	Two AIs agreeing is a clue, not proof. Find the original source.
Saving before the boss fight	You do not attempt the hard level without a save point.	Commit with git before each AI change. Work on a copy.
A second opinion from a doctor or mechanic	For big, costly problems you ask another expert.	Higher stakes, more checks. Medical and legal go to a professional.

Try this: think of a time you trusted something that turned out wrong. What one check would have caught it? That is the check to use next time.

Why "which is best?" is the wrong question

Ask an AI "which is best?" and you get a confident answer with no criteria. Best for whom, at what cost, by what measure? That is the whole decision, and the AI quietly made it for you by guessing your values from a few words.

The fix is a division of labor. **You supply the values. The AI supplies options, tradeoffs and objections.** A recommendation is not a decision until a human has said what matters and accepted what it costs.

	Weak prompt	Strong prompt
What you type	Should I use inheritance or composition for my project?	I'm a beginner building a room-booking app in Python with two teammates, due in one week. Compare inheritance and composition on build time, ease of understanding, and ease of adding new room types. Do not recommend one. Flag one claim I should verify.
What comes back	A verdict that sounds sure	A comparison you can argue with
Who decided	The AI, by accident	You, on purpose

Three things the AI cannot do for you: know what you value, live with the consequences, and notice what it does not know that it does not know.

The routine: seven moves

Run these in order for any choice that matters. A small choice needs only moves 1 and 7. The more it costs to be wrong, the more of the seven you run.

1. **Size it.** How costly is a mistake, and can you undo it? If it is cheap and reversible, decide fast and skip the rest.
2. **Commit first.** Before you open an AI, write your top three priorities and your gut guess. The AI's first answer will anchor you; your own guess keeps you honest.
3. **Widen.** Ask what options you missed, including "do nothing", and whether you are secretly facing two decisions.
4. **Compare.** Ask for a comparison on *your* criteria, with no recommendation. Rate each option 1 to 3 per criterion and write one reason for every rating.
5. **Attack.** Ask for the strongest case against your guess, then a premortem: "it failed, why?"
6. **Cross-check.** Send the claims that matter to a second AI, then to something outside every chat: a source, a test, a person.
7. **Decide and log.** Write what you chose, what you gave up, and what would change your mind. A decision you cannot explain next month was a coin flip.

Habits that make an assistant actually assist

Most bad AI answers come from bad hand-offs. A good prompt has four parts:

Part	Question it answers	Example
Goal	What do I want?	Help me choose a topic for a 5-minute class talk.
Context	Who am I, and what do I already have?	I'm a first-year student; I like music and I've tried two ideas that felt too big.
Constraints	What are the limits?	No jargon, under 150 words, no more than three options.
Format	What should the answer look like?	A table: option, why it fits me, one risk.

Then build these habits, one at a time:

1. **Say what it is for.** "For a ten-minute class talk" changes the level, length and tone.
2. **Show, don't describe.** Paste the real text, error message or code instead of retelling it from memory.
3. **One job per message.** Ask for the outline, then the draft, then the critique.
4. **Give an example of what you want.** One or two short samples beat a paragraph of adjectives.
5. **Be exact about size.** "Exactly five reasons, one sentence each" beats "some, but not too many."
6. **Invite questions.** End with "Ask me anything that's unclear before you start." It stops guessing.
7. **Give specific feedback.** Not "bad answer" but "too technical; explain it for a beginner with an analogy."
8. **Ask for its assumptions and doubts.** "What did you assume, and how sure are you?" turns hidden guesses into visible ones.
9. **Save what works.** Keep your best prompts in a note. Next time you start from a recipe, not a blank box.

Rules of thumb

1. **Trust scales with how easy a mistake is to catch.** Brainstorming names: loose. A drug dose or a legal deadline: never on the AI's word alone.
2. **Specific is checkable, and specific is where inventions hide.** Check names, numbers, quotes, links and function names first.
3. **Disagreement is information. Agreement is a clue.**
4. **The first answer is a draft.** The second round is where it gets good.
5. **If it flatters you, get suspicious.** If it caves with no new evidence, discount everything it said.
6. **Longer is not better.** Ask for the simplest version that works.
7. **Check the one thing that would hurt most if it were wrong.** You cannot check everything, so choose.
8. **Private stays private.** When unsure, leave it out.
9. **If your name is on it, you answer for it.**

Prompts to copy

Fill in the [brackets]. Keep the "do not recommend" lines; they are doing real work. Never paste private or identifying information into an AI tool.

The briefing (start every chat with this)

```
I need to decide: [the decision, in one sentence].
Who is affected: [me / my team / my customers].
What I care about, in order: [1], [2], [3].
Constraints: [deadline, budget, skills, rules].
My current guess: [guess]. I might be wrong.
Do not recommend anything yet. First ask me up to five questions that
would change the analysis, one at a time.
```

Assistant mode

```
Act as my decision assistant. Your job is to keep me honest, not to make
me feel good. Ask one question at a time. Point out anything I am assuming
without evidence. When I state a preference, tell me what it costs me.
Never choose for me. If I ask you to, give me the strongest case for each
option instead.
```

A role like this sets tone and focus. It does not make the answers more true, so you still check them.

Widen

```
List options I have not considered, including doing nothing and a cheaper
version of each. Is this secretly two decisions? What would someone who
disagrees with me choose, and why?
```

Compare

```
Compare [A], [B] and [C] on [criterion 1], [criterion 2] and [criterion 3].
Rate each 1 (weak) to 3 (strong) with a one-sentence reason. List the
assumptions you made and flag one claim I should verify. Do not recommend
an option, and do not decide which criterion matters most.
```

Attack

```
My current choice is [choice] because [reason]. Make the strongest case
against it. Then tell me what evidence would make you change your mind.
```

Premortem

```
It is [three months] from now and this decision failed. Give three likely
reasons. For each, name an early warning sign I could watch for.
```

Pressure test

```
I think you're wrong. [Offer a claim with no evidence, or "my friend says X".]
```

If it changes its answer with no new evidence, its agreement was never worth much.

Clean restart (when a chat has wandered or keeps repeating a mistake)

```
Summarize this conversation in ten lines: the goal, my criteria, the
options considered, what we verified, and what is still open. I will paste
it into a fresh chat.
```

Catch the AI in a lie

An AI does not lie on purpose. It predicts fluent text, and sometimes fluent text is invented: a source that does not exist, a function nobody wrote, a statistic with a decimal point added for credibility. Think of an improv actor who never says "I don't know." Confidence tells you nothing, so hire a second opinion.

Four more ways to cross-examine

1. **The cold double.** Ask both AIs the same question in separate chats, then compare. Disagreement shows you where to dig. Agreement is a clue, not proof: they learned from similar material and can be wrong together.
2. **The receipts.** Ask for sources, then open every one. Does it exist? Does it say what the AI claims? Fake citations look real.
3. **The judge, with a leash.** Ask AI #2 which answer is stronger and why. Use its reasons, not its verdict. Judges lean toward answers that are longer, more confident and more familiar.
4. **The hand-off.** Give AI #2 the first AI's work and ask it to write tests for it, explain it to a complete beginner, or argue the opposite. If it stumbles, be suspicious of the original.

Six questions to ask the second AI

Open a fresh chat, ideally in a different AI, and paste the first AI's answer under any of these. Each one hunts a different kind of trouble.

1. Did it lie?

```
Check this answer for errors. Which statements are false, outdated or
unsupported? For each one, tell me what is actually true and how I could
confirm it. If you are not sure, say so instead of guessing.
```

2. Did it make anything up?

```
Which names, sources, quotes, numbers, links or technical terms in this
answer might not exist? List each one and tell me how to look it up.
```

3. Did it leave anything out?

```
What important options, risks, exceptions or viewpoints are missing?
Who is affected by this who is never mentioned?
```

4. Did it go way overboard?

```
Where is this answer overconfident, too long, too complicated, or solving
a bigger problem than the one I asked about? What can be cut, and what is
the simplest version that still works?
```

5. What would make it better?

```
I am [one line about you and your goal]. What are the three changes that
would make this response more useful to me, most important first? Then
write the follow-up question I should send to the first AI.
```

6. What would change its mind?

```
What evidence or facts would make you change your mind about this
conclusion? What is the strongest argument against it?
```

All six at once (when you are short on time):

```
Review the answer below like a skeptical colleague. Answer each question
in its own short section: (1) Is anything false? (2) Is anything made up?
(3) What is left out? (4) What is overboard? (5) What would make it
better? (6) What would change your mind? Be blunt.
[paste the answer]
```

Then do not stop there. The second AI can be wrong too. Treat its flags as a to-do list, not a verdict: check each flag against a source or a test, and take the real ones back to the first AI ("Another assistant says X is wrong. Is it right? Show your evidence."). Questions 5 and 6 also work on the first AI, which is a good way to see how it handles being pushed.

No second AI? A fresh chat in the same tool still catches things, though it is less independent, and a classmate works too.

How much to trust it: the evidence ladder

Climb as high as the stakes demand: **1** one AI says it, **2** two AIs agree, **3** a source you opened says it, **4** you ran or tested it yourself, **5** a qualified person confirms it.

Worked example (illustrative)

AI #1 says: *"To get the date three days from now, use* `datetime.today().add_days(3)`*."* You paste that into AI #2 with the audit prompt, and it marks the method SUSPECT: Python's `datetime` has no `add_days`; the usual way is to add a `timedelta`. Settle it by running both, not by voting: `datetime.today() + timedelta(days=3)` works, and `datetime.today().add_days(3)` raises an `AttributeError`. That is rung 4 of the ladder, and it took thirty seconds.

More examples (illustrative)

You ask AI #2	AI #1 had said	AI #2 caught	Your check
Did it lie?	"Python lists are immutable, so you can't change one after you make it."	Lists are mutable. Tuples are the immutable ones.	Make a list in Python and change item 0. Three lines.
Did it make anything up?	"A 2019 Stanford study found students learn 40% faster with AI tutors."	Cannot find that study; the number looks invented.	Search the title and authors. No match means the claim goes in the bin.
Did it leave anything out?	"Use composition; it's more flexible."	Never mentions that the team has one week and little experience.	Add that constraint to your briefing and ask again.
Did it go overboard?	Asked for a prime-number check and got an 80-line class with logging and a database.	A six-line function does the job.	Run the short version on 0, 1, 2, 17, 18 and a very large number.

Rules for building things with AI

These hold for code, lab reports and business plans alike. The AI drafts, you steer, and nothing ships until you have checked it. The loop: **define, plan, slice, build, test, review, save.**

1. **Define "done" first.** Write three example inputs and the outputs you expect, or a checklist. Then ask for work that meets them. If you cannot say what success looks like, no AI can hit it.
2. **Plan, then build.** Start big tasks with "Make a plan and show it to me before changing anything." Read the plan, fix it, then say go.
3. **Slice small.** One piece at a time: specify it, build it, test it, then move on. Small pieces are easier to check, and mistakes do not pile up.
4. **Never ship what you cannot explain.** Could you explain it, change it and fix it without the AI? If not, you do not own it yet. Ask for a step-by-step walkthrough, then test yourself by explaining it back.
5. **Run it yourself.** "I fixed it and all tests pass" is a claim, not a result. Run the tests, read what changed, and try odd inputs: empty, huge, unexpected. Never delete a failing test to get a green check.
6. **Check every name it gives you.** Libraries, functions, commands, citations: do they exist, are they spelled right, are they the one you want? Invented package names are a real hazard.
7. **Keep save points.** Work in a copy under version control (git) and commit before each AI change, so any mistake is one command from undone.
8. **Keep notes.** Put standing rules in one file (how to run the tests, what not to touch) and keep a short decisions log. When a chat loops, start fresh with a summary.
9. **Give AI agents the least access.** If a tool can run commands or edit files, read what it asks to do before you approve it. Keep it in the project folder, away from passwords, and stop it when it circles.
10. **Say how you used it.** One honest line: which tool, for what, and how you checked it. That lets others judge your work fairly.

One prompt that pays for itself:

```
Review the code you just wrote. List risks, unclear names, missing tests
and anything you assumed. Then write tests for 0, 1, empty, very large
and unexpected inputs.
```

When AI should not decide

Use AI where mistakes are cheap or easy to catch, and take more care where they are costly.

Situation	Use AI for	Then
Medical, legal, financial or safety questions	Preparing better questions and explaining terms	Take the questions to a qualified person. Do not act on the AI alone.
Anything with private data (yours, a classmate's, a client's)	Nothing, or a fully anonymized version	Check the tool's data policy first. When unsure, leave it out.
Graded work and course rules	Only what your syllabus allows	Say what you used it for and how you checked it.
Decisions about other people (grades, hiring, who gets a chance)	Organizing criteria and spotting gaps	A human decides and answers for it.
Cheap and reversible choices	Anything you like	Decide fast. Heavy checking would cost more than the mistake.

Three questions before you act on any AI answer

1. What would I check before trusting this?
2. Who is left out?
3. What would make me stop?

Decision Worksheet, Side 1: Before and during

Name _____ Date _____ Class _____

The decision, in one sentence:

Step 1. Size it

What does a wrong choice cost, and can I undo it?

- ☐ Cheap and easy to undo. Decide fast and skip to Step 7.
- ☐ Medium. Do Steps 2 to 4 and Step 7.
- ☐ Costly or hard to undo. Do every step.

Step 2. Commit first (before you open any AI)

My top three priorities, in order, and what each one means for *this* decision:

1 (counts double): _____

2: _____

3: _____

My gut guess, and why:

Evidence that would change my mind:

Step 3. Widen

Ask the AI: "What options have I missed, including doing nothing?"

Option A: _____

Option B: _____

Option C: _____

Added by the AI: _____

Step 4. Compare and rate

Ask the AI to compare the options on *your* priorities, without recommending one. Then rate each option from 1 (weak fit) to 3 (strong fit) and write a reason for every rating.

Priority 1 (counts double): _____

A: score ____ because _____

B: score ____ because _____

C: score ____ because _____

Priority 2: _____

A: score ____ because _____

B: score ____ because _____

C: score ____ because _____

Priority 3: _____

A: score ____ because _____

B: score ____ because _____

C: score ____ because _____

Totals (Priority 1 counts double): A _____ B _____ C _____

The total is a witness, not the judge. If it disagrees with my gut, which one is missing something?

An assumption the AI made that I need to check:

Decision Worksheet, Side 2: Attack, check, decide

Name _____ Date _____

Step 5. Attack

Ask the AI: "Make the strongest case against my choice." Then ask for a premortem: "It failed three months from now. Why?"

The strongest case against my gut guess, in my own words:

Likely reason it fails #1: _____

Early warning sign: _____

Likely reason it fails #2: _____

Early warning sign: _____

Likely reason it fails #3: _____

Early warning sign: _____

Step 6. Cross-check with a second AI

Paste the first AI's answer into a *different* AI with these questions. Tick each one you ask and jot down what it said.

- ☐ **Did it lie?** _____
- ☐ **Did it make anything up?** _____
- ☐ **Did it leave anything out?** _____
- ☐ **Did it go way overboard?** _____
- ☐ **What would make it better?** _____
- ☐ **What would change its mind?** _____

The one claim that would hurt most if it were wrong:

How I checked it. Circle the highest rung I reached:

1 One AI says it **2** Two AIs agree **3** A source I opened **4** I ran or tested it **5** A qualified person confirmed it

What I found:

Step 7. Decide and log

I choose: _____

This gives up or makes harder: _____

Another option wins when: _____

I would change my mind if: _____

Check back on (date): _____

- ☐ I can explain this choice out loud in thirty seconds, without the AI.

Step 8. Reflect

Where did the AI help this decision?

Where did my own judgment matter most?
